

AI SEARCH PRACTICAL GUIDE

How to Get Found by ChatGPT, Perplexity, and
Google AI Overviews



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Introduction

AI Search — also called AEO (Answer Engine Optimization) or GEO (Generative Engine Optimization) — is the new search paradigm. Unlike traditional SEO (which delivers blue links), AI Search delivers direct answers generated by artificial intelligence.

When someone asks ChatGPT "what's the best AI tool for marketing?", the answer it gives is the result of a **retrieval and synthesis** process — and your brand can (and should) be there.

This guide shows, in 5 practical steps, how to optimize your content to be cited by generative AI.

Step 1: Understand How AIs "See" Your Content

Unlike Google, which indexes pages and ranks by links and relevance, AIs like ChatGPT, Claude, and Perplexity:

1. **Crawl the web** — but not the same way as Googlebot. They prioritize sources with clean structure, authority, and frequent updates.
2. **Extract fragments** — not entire pages. They look for paragraphs, lists, and definitions that answer specific questions.
3. **Synthesize multiple sources** — your brand can be cited alongside competitors or established authorities.

What this means: your content needs to be extractable. Dense but well-structured paragraphs have a higher chance of being cited than pages full of navigation and ads.

Step 2: Structure Your Content for Extraction

Generative AIs use **Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)** techniques. They:

- » Divide your text into chunks
- » Index these chunks semantically
- » Retrieve the most relevant chunks for each question

To optimize:

- » Use descriptive headings (`<h2>` , `<h3>`) that are clear questions or topics
- » Write short paragraphs (2-4 sentences) that work as standalone answers
- » Include lists (`<ul>` , `<ol>`) for structured information
- » Define technical terms within the sentence itself (e.g., "RAG, or Retrieval-Augmented Generation, is...")

Ideal format:

```
<h2>[Question or Topic]</h2>
```

```
[Direct answer in 1-2 sentences]
```

```
[Context or depth in 2-3 sentences]
```

- Point 1
- Point 2
- Point 3

Step 3: Optimize for Natural Questions (FAQ Schema + NLP)

Als receive questions in natural language. Your content should answer real questions your audience asks.

Techniques:

1. **Map real questions** — use Google's "People Also Ask," AnswerThePublic, Reddit, and communities in your niche.
2. **Create FAQ sections** — each question variant becomes an `<h3>` or FAQ Schema item.
3. **Use natural language** — write how you'd speak to a client, not a technical manual.
4. **Include explicit definitions** — "X is Y that does Z" is a format Als love to cite.

FAQ Schema is CRITICAL for Google AI Overviews. Implement JSON-LD with complete questions and answers (not just "see more").

Step 4: Build Citable Authority

Als prioritize sources with demonstrated authority. To build authority:

1. **Cite primary sources** — studies, papers, official data. Als trust content that references verifiable sources more.
2. **Keep content updated** — Als have temporal preferences. Content with recent "last modified" dates have an advantage.
3. **Generate quality backlinks** — even in AI Search, links from trusted domains matter (authority signal).
4. **Have multi-platform presence** — Als index Wikipedia, LinkedIn, Medium, Substack, GitHub. Your brand across multiple sources increases citation chances.
5. **Produce original content** — Als detect and penalize fabricated (AI-generated spam) content. Content with original data and analysis is preferred.

Step 5: Monitor and Measure Your AI Presence

Unlike SEO, which has Google Search Console, AI Search is still new territory. But measurement is already possible:

1. **SearchGPT / Perplexity** — search for key terms in your niche and see if your brand appears in responses.
2. **AI Overviews** — search Google for industry terms and see if the AI Overview cites your brand.
3. **AI visibility tools** — platforms like Brand24, Mente, and specialized AI Search tools are starting to offer AI citation metrics.
4. **Share of AI Voice (SAV)** — emerging metric: how many times your brand is cited vs. competitors in AI responses.

Practical metric: for each article you publish, ask ChatGPT, Claude, and Perplexity a related question. Does your brand appear in the response? If not, review the structure.

Quick Checklist

- » Headings are clear questions or topics
- » Paragraphs have 2-4 sentences (extractable)
- » Lists and explicit definitions are present
- » FAQ Schema implemented
- » Content updated within the last 6 months
- » Answers real audience questions
- » Cites primary sources and verifiable data
- » Multi-platform presence (LinkedIn, Medium, GitHub)

Conclusion

AI Search is not a passing trend — it's the new layer of digital discovery. While your competitors still optimize only for Google, you can dominate the next paradigm.

Start with one article, structure for extraction, implement FAQ Schema, and monitor your presence. In 30 days, you'll have concrete data on your AI visibility.

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